



T. ORTEGA GAINES/Staff

Environmental heroes line up with shovels Friday before planting 11 bald cypress trees at Greenville Neighborhood Park in Charlotte. Those honored by the Earth Coalition of Charlotte

Mecklenburg are (from left) Roy Alexander, Debbie Hubbard, Thomas Huggins, Ramsey Penegar, Lorraine Loken, Deb Sue Griffin, Tecil Curlee and Oren McCullough.

'Environmental heroes' honored

By LINN BROSAN
Staff Writer

GASTONIA — Ramsey Penegar believes that if everyone makes a few small sacrifices, it could have a big impact on the Earth.

"This is the only planet we can live on," said the Holbrook Junior High ninth-grader. "We need to all work together."

For her part, Ramsey, 15, advocates recycling. She refuses to eat anything served on or in plastic foam containers and has collected more than 300 signatures on a petition to ban the plastic foam from Gaston County public schools.

The Earth Coalition of Charlotte Mecklenburg honored her Friday by planting a bald cypress tree in Greenville Neighborhood Park in Charlotte. Other trees were planted for 10 other "environmental heroes."

Ramsey, daughter of Oscar and Juddie



Ramsey

Penegar of Gastonia, thinks everyone should stop buying any kind of plastic foam containers.

Making the material, which contains fluorocarbons, puts a strain on the environment.

"Fluorocarbons eat away at the ozone, which is why we have a big hole in the ozone now," Ramsey said.

Throwing the containers away is another problem.

"It never biodegrades. And you can't burn it . . . because of the fumes," she said.

Ansley Scofield, nutrition director for Gaston County schools, said the schools won't stop using plastic foam, but they'll start recycling it early next year.

The plan is part of the school system's overall recycling effort, which has been developed in the past few years.

In addition to Ramsey, 10 other people or organizations were honored as Earth Day heroes. Here's a list:

■ Roy Alexander, who helps coordinate workshops, field trips and learning vacations with Science Museums of Charlotte.

■ Scott Collins, who started UNC Charlotte's recycling program and helped the university reduce its aluminum can trash by 44% in a year.

■ Tecil Curlee, longtime composter, who has donated recycling proceeds to the Humane Society of Charlotte.

■ Deb Sue Griffin, who helped start the Carolina Raptor Center and conducts programs at Camp Thunderbird's Environmental Education Center.

■ Thomas Huggins of the Lake Norman Yacht Club, who encourages proper disposal of foam dock-flotation materials and pressure-treated wood.

■ Dr. Jim Horton, chairman of the Mecklenburg County Environmental Protection Commission, who has pushed for watershed protection at Mountain Island Lake.

■ Lorraine Loken, who teaches children how to conserve drinking water as Water Woman of the Charlotte-Mecklenburg Utility Department.

■ Oren McCullough, a retired mail carrier, who recycles paper and cleans up his west Charlotte neighborhood.

■ Sierra Club Inner City Outings program, under David Drum, Debbie Hubbard and Mara Malakoff, which takes youngsters hiking, camping, canoeing and on other activities.

■ Douglas Edward Simpson, who started an aluminum-can recycling program and has contributed recycling proceeds to the Humane Society of Union County.

□ □ □

Staff writer Ann Helms contributed to this article. A version of this article appeared in *The Gaston Observer*, the *Gaston and Lincoln counties* and *Kings Mountain* edition of *The Observer*.